

CHAPTER ONE: A WORLD OF DARKNESS

*"Man is least himself when he talks in his own person.
Give him a mask, and he will tell you the truth."*

— Oscar Wilde, *Intentions*

The world of **Changeling** is a dreary version of our world.

Dreamers are taught that they won't amount to much, that their creativity is a pale imitation of what came before. In fact, dreams are for hobbies, not for facing the world as adults. Well-meaning, or envious, parents and friends consistently suppress talent in their loved ones, secure in the knowledge that they're saving them from a huge mistake. Repeated altercations eviscerate creativity until all that remains is overwhelming self-doubt and insecurity.

Every day is a struggle. Unstable markets, raging wars resulting in refugee crises, pandemic reports, and media pandering to fear and panic result in short-lived ambitions. Meanwhile the wealthiest of the wealthy remain unable to connect with expressed discontent. Instead, they only look forward to the next profitable acquisition. It's not that they don't care, they are just unable to grasp circumstances beyond their own social circle. And so, money becomes the way of life.

Sounds a lot like our world, doesn't it?

In **Changeling** these elements are greatly enhanced by the suffocating reality that actively dampens humanity's spirit. Nuances diminish in a world suppressed by darkness. Although people dream, they feel as if everything has already been done, and all that remains is to conform. Daily struggles suppress empathy. Banality is an active and growing force that surges through the world, keeping joy muted, love from reaching truly inspiring heights, and ensuring that humanity is content with what is instead of what could be.

Against all odds, true Dreamers, from all walks of life, and in every corner of the world, still thrive. They're not many, but they're out there, creating beautiful works of art, music, and literature, inventing new and unique technology that revolutionizes the way of life, or teaching generations of children through memorable and inspiring techniques. They infuse the world with Glamour, the stuff of dreams, that wards off the monotony of Banality and keeps the prophesied Long Winter at bay. Dreamers know, on some level, that they aren't alone, that the magical